Likes say far more about views than the follower count

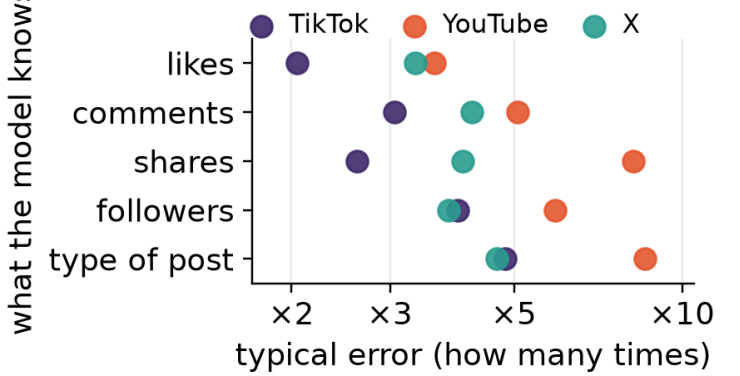
Platforms often hide how many people saw a post, so Brand24 has to estimate it. We have 12,500 posts from 5 platforms. True views exist only on TikTok, YouTube and part of X, so that is where we test what works.

How far off are we?



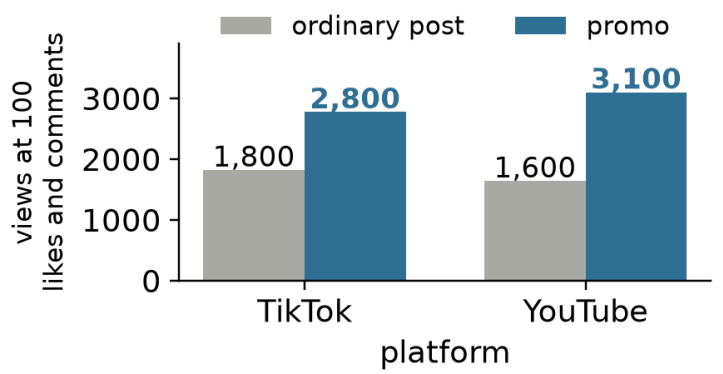
A constant × followers is off 7-8 times. A simple model with reactions is off 2-3 times, even without tuning. On X, where we can compare, Brand24's reach is off about 12 times and our model about 3 times.

What matters most?



A model that knows just one thing about a post does best with likes. On TikTok likes alone give an error of about ×2. The type of post alone says almost nothing.

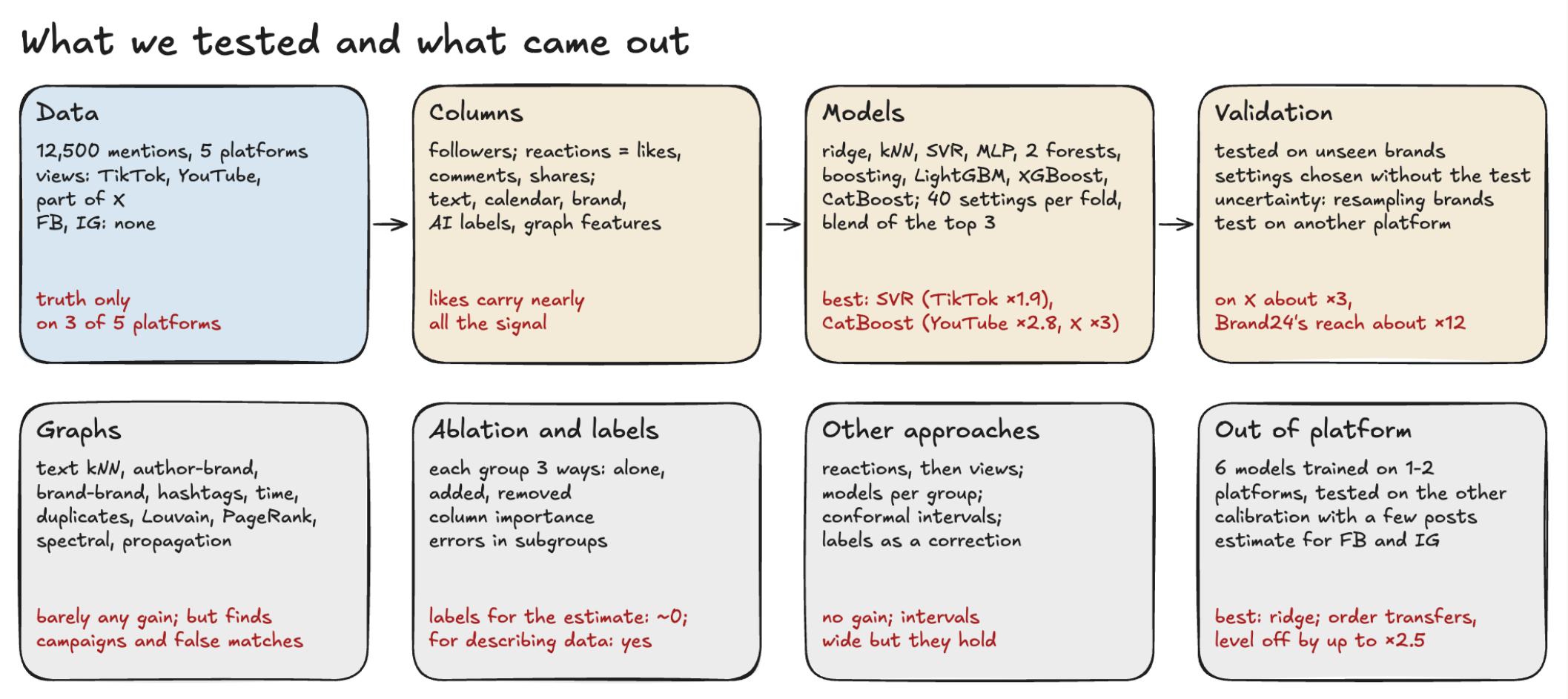
Does the kind of post help?



AI labelled each post as ordinary, promo or spam, plus its tone. This barely improves the estimate. It does show that at the same reactions, promo gets 1.5-1.9 times the views.

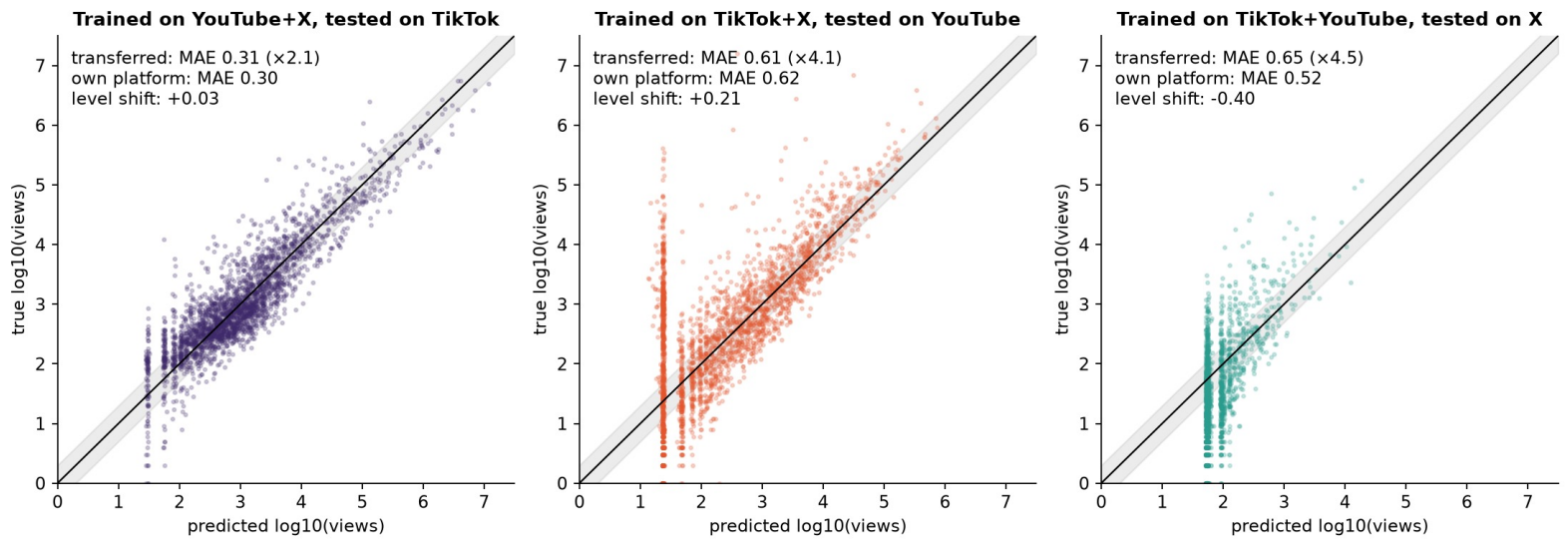
"Off by ×3": typically 3 times too high or too low. The range for 90% of posts is wider: ×4 (TikTok), ×10 (YouTube), ×11 (X) each way. Tested on brands the model has not seen. Reactions are likes, comments and shares. Brand24's reach may not be the same as views.

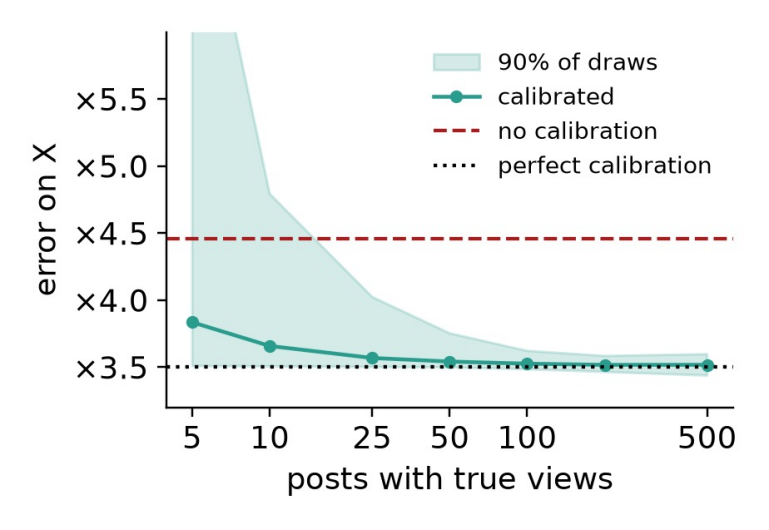
We tested 10 kinds of model: the best are off 2-3 times, and extra data and graphs barely change that



Best after tuning: SVR on TikTok, CatBoost on YouTube and X. Input: followers, reactions, missing-value flags. 40 sets of settings per model. Main limitation: no human has checked the AI labels yet.

A model from another platform ranks posts well but can miss the scale; about 50 posts fix that





Another platform

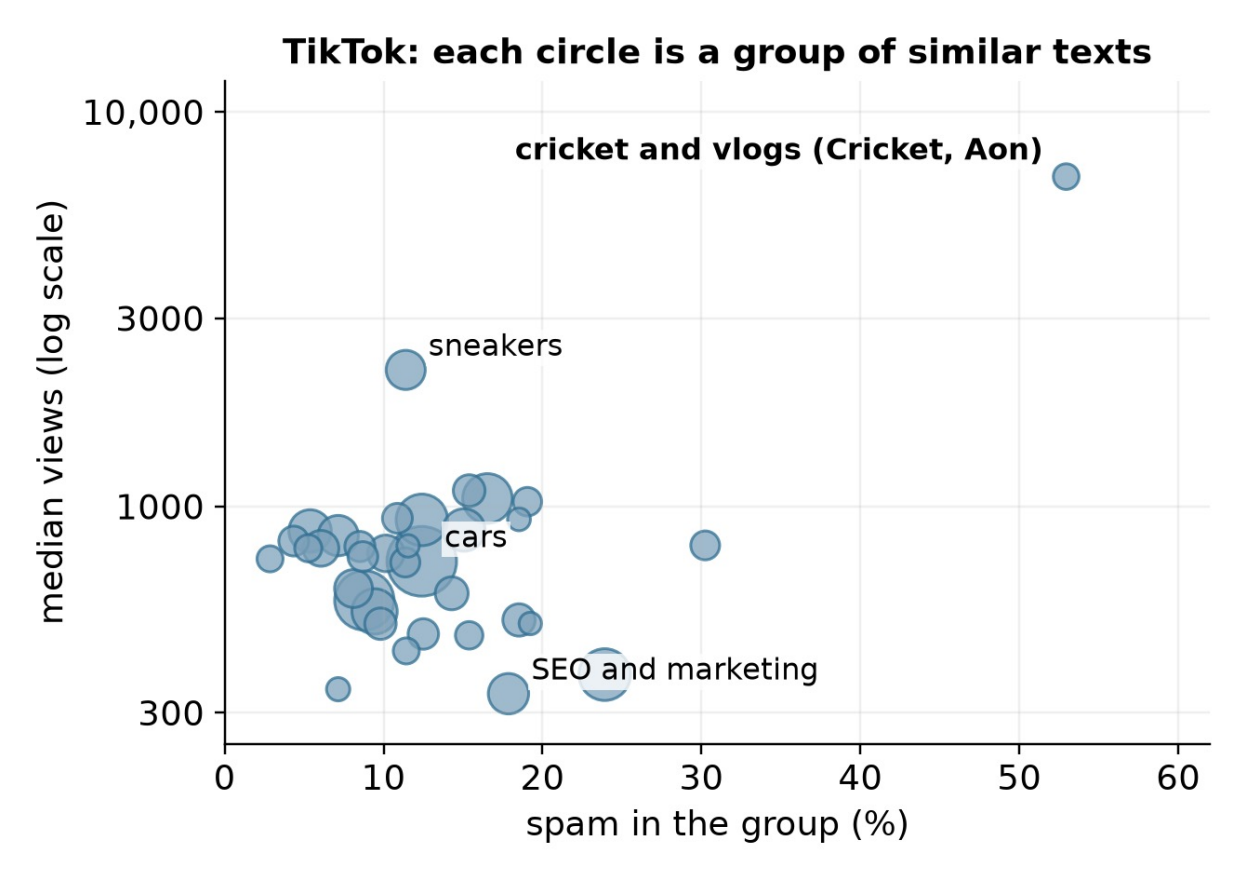
A simple model (ridge) trained on two platforms, using only likes and comments. Off by: TikTok ×2.1, YouTube ×4.1, nearly as on own data. On X ×4.5 against ×3.3, because all posts are overestimated about 2.5 times.

A small sample is enough

On X about 50 posts with true views remove the overestimate: the error falls from ×4.5 to ×3.5, close to perfect calibration (×3.5). Brand24 has no such Facebook or Instagram sample, so we plan to collect our own.

Left: ridge trained on two platforms, tested on the third, test brands removed from training. Log10 axes. Calibration was tested only where the truth is known. On FB and IG the estimate depends on the source by ×1.7 and ×2.4.

Graphs barely improve the estimate, but they show what is really in the data



How it works: each post is a point and similar texts are linked. The Louvain algorithm splits the graph into groups by itself, with no views or labels.

For the estimate: 18 variants of graph features give at most +0.009 (YouTube). Label propagation even makes it worse.

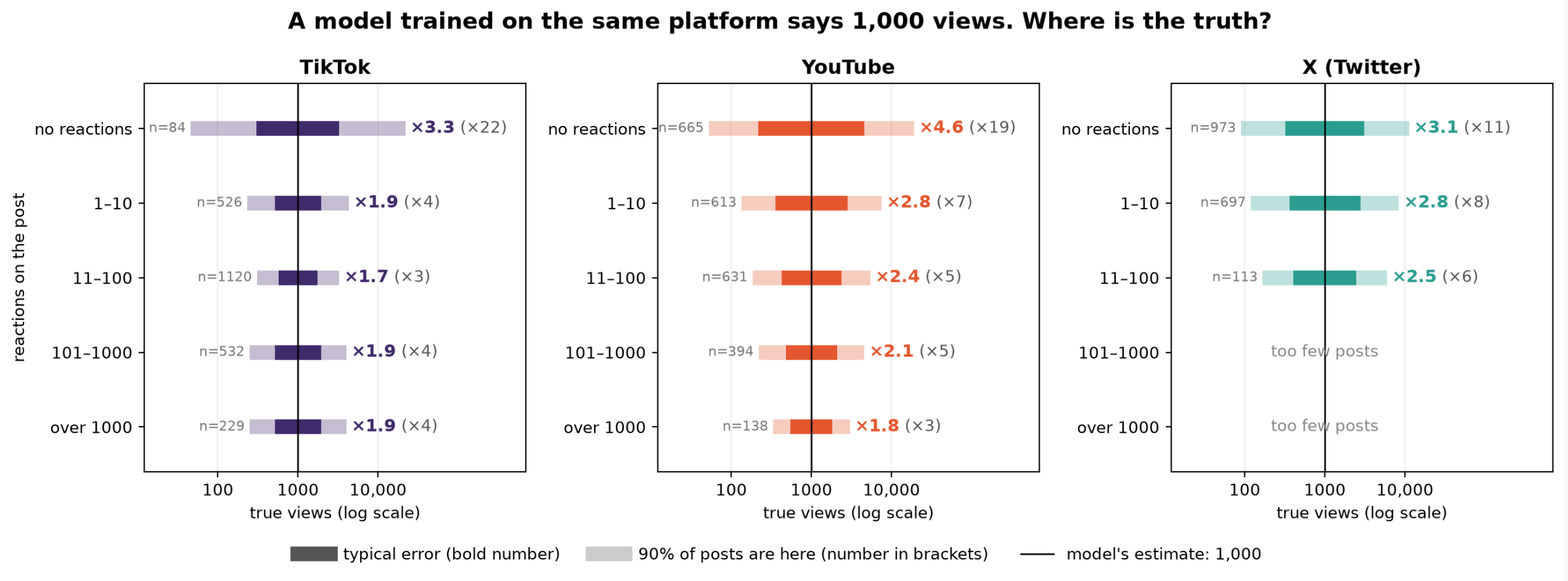
For describing the data: industries emerge: cars, hotels, fast food. 38% of near-identical posts on X are spam, against 9% in the rest.

A curiosity: mentions of the Cricket Wireless mobile network on TikTok are about the sport: 0 of 20 about the company. Keyword monitoring caught something else. Small sample.

Groups are moderately stable (ARI 0.61-0.71). They match brands (NMI 0.49-0.65), not post type (NMI 0.04-0.08). False matches were checked on one example; their frequency is unknown.

BACKUP · UNCERTAINTY

Without reactions the estimate is uncertain; with reactions the range narrows sharply



Model: CatBoost trained on the same platform, on followers and reactions, tested on unseen brands. The range at zero reactions is wide, so such an estimate should be marked as uncertain. An interval per reaction tier covers about 90% of posts; the exception is TikTok at zero reactions, with too little data.